

Local versus Other: Hawaiian Pidgin & Covert Prestige

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Pidgin originated on the sugar plantations back in the 1830s. Although the cane fields of Hawaii have long since been abandoned, Pidgin persists. What purpose does Pidgin now serve in a state whose population is, for the most part, perfectly capable of communicating in Standard American English (SAE)? This paper looks at what it means to be ‘Local’ in Hawaii and how Pidgin is used as a form of covert prestige to further divide Locals from non-Locals. Based on six empirical studies analyzing the use, history, and perceptions of Pidgin, this paper will reveal how entrenched Pidgin is in many Hawaii residents’ sense of identity and how this can lead to conflicting feelings of one’s membership, or lack of membership, in the Local community. Hawaiian Creole and Pidgin can be used interchangeably, but for this paper I will use Pidgin exclusively because this is how the language is commonly referred to by the people who speak it.

First, a brief history of Pidgin in Hawaii and its changing roles relative to English and Hawaiian will be presented. Secondly, how Pidgin is perceived in various contexts will be addressed. Next, the question of who is and isn’t considered Local will be explored, particularly as it pertains to speaking Pidgin. I will then look at a study of how Pidgin is used in television commercials to infuse them with Local-ness and how its use reflects notions of class. Finally, this paper will explore how Pidgin is used as a form of covert prestige to divide Locals from the *Other*, especially in humor.

Hawaii's Language Shifts

Considering the changing roles of Pidgin in Hawaii cannot be effectively done without also acknowledging Pidgin's shifting importance relative to Hawaiian and English. The first sugar plantation in Hawaii was established in 1835. (Furukawa, 2007; Marlow & Giles, 2008) In 1853, ethnic Hawaiians were the largest demographic in Hawaii (n=71,019) and Hawaiian was the dominant language (Marlow & Giles, 2008). However, between 1852 and 1913, Hawaii's burgeoning sugar industry attracted immigrant labor from Japan (n=70,000), the Philippines (n=63,000), China (n=56,700), Portugal (n=17,000), Korea (n=3,500), and to a lesser extent, various other countries (Marlow & Giles, 2008). Pidgin emerged in the early 1900s out of the necessity for plantation laborers of various first languages to communicate with one another. (Lockwood & Saft, 2016; Furukawa, 2007; Marlow & Giles, 2008) Initially, the common language uniting these speakers was both Hawaiian and Pidgin. As a result, early iterations of Pidgin pulled heavily from the Hawaiian language (Lockwood & Saft, 2016). However, as English slowly grew to become the dominant language that it is today in Hawaii, Pidgin followed. Thus, Hawaii's particular brand of Pidgin is based on English, with Hawaiian, Japanese, Portuguese, Filipino (Tagalog and Ilokano) and Cantonese components (Lockwood & Saft, 2016; Marlow & Giles, 2008). Eventually, Pidgin became the primary language spoken on the plantations. Subsequent generations that descended from these laborers spoke a stable Pidgin as their L1, with set and predictable grammar patterns (Furukawa, 2007). By the 1970s, the Hawaiian language was virtually extinct as Hawaiian-speaking parents felt English was the more advantageous language to teach their children. However, in response to a "shift in language

ideologies,” (Lockwood & Saft, 2016, p. 2) both English and Hawaiian became the official languages of Hawaii in 1978, leading to the establishment of several Hawaiian-medium schools (Lockwood & Saft, 2016). Whereas the Hawaiian language has enjoyed nearly 50 years of overt prestige and legitimacy, Pidgin resides in a curious grey area, lacking official recognition as an actual language despite being spoken by nearly half of Hawaii’s population (n=600,000) (Furukawa, 2007; Lockwood & Saft, 2016).

Fo’ speak Pidgin, fo’ no speak Pidgin – das da question, ya?

Hawaii’s relationship with Pidgin has been a complicated one. In 1995, a newspaper quoted a local businessman’s view that growing up surrounded by Pidgin was “like being sentenced to a life of poverty” (Lockwood & Saft, 2016, pp. 3). In a study conducted by Morgan and Giles (2008), a 29 year old *kama’aina* (long-term resident of Hawaii) who moved to Hawaii as a child expressed a preference for speaking Pidgin in informal contexts, but received disapproval from his mother for sounding “stupid” or “inferior”. Other participants of this study feared being criticized for not speaking Pidgin enough or “talking *Haole*”, speaking the SAE associated with Caucasians from the mainland. Others celebrate Pidgin and its place in Hawaii’s culture. According to Frank Delima, a well-known Local comedian specializing in ethnic humor, “Hawaii is Local. Hawaii is Pidgin.” (Labrador, 2004, pp.17). For many, Pidgin represents what they perceive to be Hawaii’s history of racial harmony: the acceptance, inclusion, and mixing of many races and cultures. Labrador believes that Pidgin “has brought people together in spite of their differences in ancestral culture and language and has created a ‘local’ culture...” (as cited in *Da Pidgin Coup* & University of Hawaii at Manoa, 1999, pp. 296).

Pidgin in Education

Ben Cayetano, Hawaii’s fifth governor (1994 - 2002) and a Local man of Filipino

descent, publically denounced the use of Pidgin, especially in schools, as detrimental to the future of Hawaii's children. Despite an attempt in 1987 to ban Pidgin from being spoken in schools state-wide, a recent study conducted by Lockwood and Saft (2016) revealed that the majority of the 18 professors they interviewed at the University of Hawaii at Hilo felt favorably towards Pidgin being used in the classroom, both by the students and, when appropriate, the instructors.

College campuses are now seeing a rise in the need to elevate Pidgin's role in academia. Since 1999, a language activist group at the University of Hawaii at Manoa (UH Manoa), called "Da Pidgin Coup", has gone to great lengths to promote Pidgin as a legitimate language in its own right. Various members of Da Pidgin Coup have written and published the first book of Pidgin grammar, created films using Pidgin-speaking students and faculty to promote awareness of Pidgin, and headed workshops focused on dispelling the misconceptions surrounding Pidgin (Lockwood and Saft, 2016). However, while UH Manoa currently offers several courses on Hawaiian language and culture, there is only one course that (loosely) addresses Pidgin and Local culture (<http://www.catalog.hawaii.edu/courses/departments/haw.htm>).

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Conclusion

Pidgin is no longer used as a lingua franca between people of different L1s but is now used to show closeness with friends and family, indicate cultural membership, or establish boundaries between Locals and those considered *Other*. The use of Pidgin in both comedy and advertising serve to reinforce these functions. As Pidgin shows no signs of dying with the

coming of new generations, the question now seems to be whether Hawaii should recognize it as an official language with all the overt prestige and legitimacy of English and Hawaiian, or should it continue to be relegated to informal interactions between friends and family. If Hawaii is to truly rise to its reputation as a “multicultural paradise”, than an honest look at Pidgin and Local culture as it relates to Hawaii’s history, its current practices of inclusion and exclusion, and the class differences associated with language use must be addressed.

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